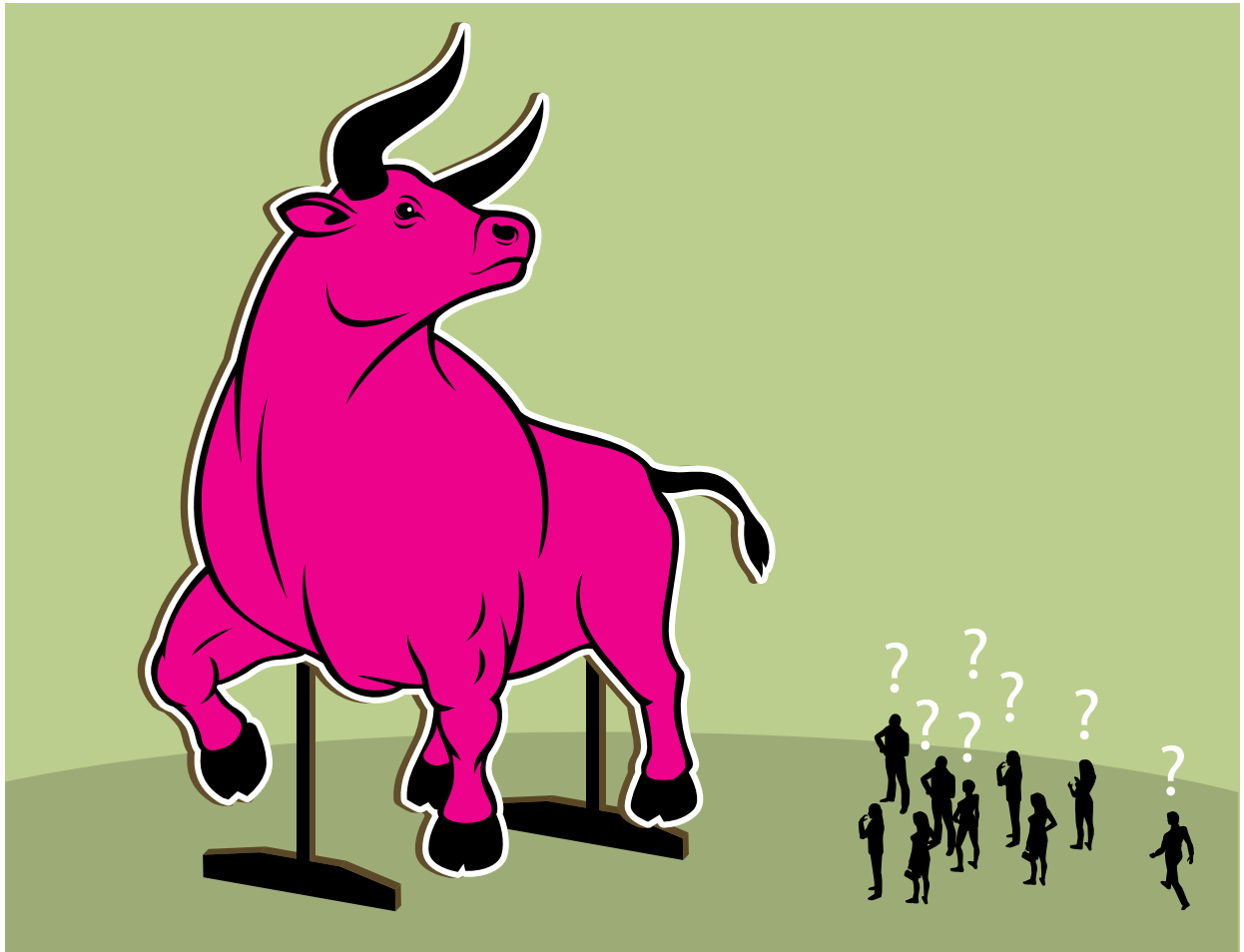




The ongoing Joshimath crisis is a reminder of the huge ecological challenge that confronts India in the coming decades. Disasters in Shimla, Darjeeling, Manali will surely follow and it is not just our mountains that are at risk. By 2047, some of our main cities like Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai may face rampant floods because of rising water levels. Severe droughts and heat waves may wreak havoc on lives and livelihoods every year.

Pollution may have rendered metros like Delhi utterly hazardous to live in, as choked infrastructure may have done to Bengaluru and Mumbai. As rural to urban migration gathers more momentum, our cities will struggle to cope and in a couple of decades the situation may

have become totally unmanageable. Perhaps these signs are clear already, which may explain the steady exodus of skilled professionals from India to greener pastures. Last year, nearly 200,000 Indians migrated away, thousands of them millionaires. By 2047, we could be losing millions of skilled citizens each year to developed countries.

Finally, there is the matter of India's place in the Human Development Index (HDI). For a country of our size and growing importance, to be stuck at a lowly 132 out of 191 countries on the HDI index is a matter of grave concern. With economic growth, our position would have improved from this abysmal ranking but it may not have lifted us to the league of the top 66 nations in this

list which are considered developed. Till that happens, GDP numbers are quite meaningless. They may give us bragging rights, but not have made India a great country to live in.

India@100 will have many things to celebrate. All things said, it would still have been a remarkable journey for a relatively young nation. But the experience of China should teach us that size isn't everything. Many smaller nations have blossomed into wonderful success stories without boasting of trillion-dollar economies. It's the 'internals' which matter more, and it is on those that our policymakers would do well to keep an eye on as we move from 75 to 100.

It is only then that 1.6 billion Indians would rise together to applaud a truly great century. **BT**